

BYJU'S WORLD
Byju Raveendran and family with Shah Rukh Khan (left); in his famous black tee; with father Raveendran (below)

Both Sharma and Raveendran saw their businesses profit from black swan events–Paytm due to demonetisation in 2016, and BYJU'S because of Covid

first began. Here, then, is the story of the rise and fall of Vijay Shekhar Sharma and Byju Raveendran.

FIRST MOVER PAYTM

Vijay Shekhar Sharma started his entrepreneurial journey early. He went to school in Harduaganj, a small town near Aligarh, in Uttar Pradesh, where his father taught at a government school and the family had trouble making ends meet. He learnt English on his own so that he could clear the entrance examinations to engineering colleges. He gained admission to the Delhi College of Engineering (now Delhi Technological University) and, while studying, he wrote web programs for companies that earned him plenty of pocket money. While still in his teens, Sharma started XS Corps!, a content management system company, with three friends, which they sold for $1 million to a US firm in 1999. With the money it got them, they launched an online search engine for telephone numbers called One97 Communications, so named because 197 was the analog telephone directory helpline number. When the money got tight, Sharma's partners pulled out and he converted the website to offer news, cricket scores and music. Later, backed by private phone companies, he began selling online prepaid products such as SMS and data packs and roaming services. Sharma was among the first to realise the potential of smartphones after the launch of mobile apps, including those for gaming. At that time, there was no payments system to facilitate

and with 15,000 employees, offers free classes, raising brand value manifold

↘ In July 2021, acquired Aakash, a bricks-and-mortar coaching network, for close to a billion dollars in an "all-cash deal"

↘ By Mar. 2022, BYJU'S valuation had touched $22 bn, it's a Qatar FIFA World Cup sponsor, even the Indian cricket team jerseys sport its name, a three-year sponsorship deal that started in July 2019

THE DESCENT

↘ In Oct. 2022, BYJU'S valuation plummets, dropping to $6 bn in just six months. Company lays off 18,000 employees. Still spends on getting Lionel Messi as its global ambassador in November

↘ BCCI sues BYJU'S for default on dues of over Rs 158 crore in Indian cricket



team jersey deal

↘ Amid talk of a funds crunch, Byju pens an emotional letter to staff in early March announcing that all pending salaries for Jan. 2024 have been credited. "Two days ago, I saw my father, the most resilient person I know, breaking down after seeing the news [of the company's woes]... My father is my role model; I am a teacher because he once was; I am an entrepreneur because he always taught me to follow my dreams. That he, my rock-solid support, was moved to tears made me feel a sudden pain"

– From media reports